

'THIS IS JUST THE BEGINNING FOR INDIAN ATHLETICS'

Fresh off a silver medal at the Asian Athletics Championships, **Tejaswin Shankar** reflects on India's rapid rise in track and field as he brings alive the gritty, emotional roller-coaster of the decathlon.

I landed in South Korea two days before the decathlon. It was my first time this far east — the farthest I'd ever been from home — and I could feel a quiet sense of anticipation building up inside me. My body felt good, my mind was calm, and for once, there were no lingering injuries like the one I carried into the Nationals. Spirits were high.

We were staying in a beautiful facility. And the best part? Everyone had their own room. For someone like me — who tends to travel with half a sporting goods store — this was a blessing. **Ten spikes, a javelin, discus, tape, massage balls, recovery tools... you name it, I had it. My room was an organised mess, but it was my own little corner of controlled chaos. Just how I like it.**

The Indian team was a fresh mix of new energy. I had trained with some of them at the pre-Asians camp in

Thiruvananthapuram about three weeks earlier, but this group felt different. Passionate, intense, expressive — this new generation of Indian athletes is something else. They're there to win, and they wear their hearts on their sleeves. But they also know how to have fun, how to laugh, and how to lift each other up. There was an energy about them that made me proud to be part of this transition.

Since my competition started on the 27th of May, I did my pre-meet shake-out on the 26th. I felt springy, sharp, and ready. I caught up with a few friends from other countries — the usual pre-meet chats about training, competitions, and how the season's been going. One of my favourite things about international meets is the sense of belonging. This is our tribe. We may be from different places, but we speak the same language — the language of the sport, of pushing limits, of purpose.

A lot has changed since my first senior international in 2015. Back then, physios and doctors were few and far between. Now, our support staff is a core part of the Indian team experience. The physios, coaches, and doctors work relentlessly behind the scenes. And even the coaches, who once primarily raised their voices to correct us, now offer calm encouragement and insight. The



Charging ahead: Tejaswin (second from right) started Day 2 with a near-perfect hurdles race. ASIAN ATHLETICS